

Insight-to-Action Gap

SLIBRARY 01 · SHEET 5 / 5

Why analysis rarely changes behaviour

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

The Insight-to-Action Gap is the recurring shortfall between the insights an organisation generates and the decisions or behaviours it actually changes — the distance between knowing and doing.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Articulated by Jeffrey Pfeffer and Robert Sutton in The Knowing-Doing Gap (2000) and echoed across analytics-adoption research.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Pfeffer and Sutton observed that firms accumulate knowledge yet fail to act on it; the concept names this failure so it can be managed rather than assumed away.

FIGURE 1 · INSIGHT-TO-ACTION GAP



Figure 1. A schematic of the Insight-to-Action Gap as applied in BARBM312 (illustrative).

HOW IT IS USED

Insights are tracked through to the decisions they were meant to change; where no behaviour shifts, the analysis is treated as waste and the cause diagnosed.

WHEN IT IS USED

When reviewing analytics or AI programmes that produce reports nobody acts on, and when designing for adoption rather than mere production of insight.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Analytics leaders, change managers and executives accountable for realising value from data.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

It relocates the bottleneck from analysis to action, challenging the assumption that better insight automatically yields better outcomes.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

DIKW Pyramid · Slibrary 1

OODA Loop · Slibrary 1

Decision-Intelligence Stack · Slibrary 1

Data Value Chain · Slibrary 1

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Pfeffer, J. and Sutton, R.I. (2000) The Knowing-Doing Gap. Boston: HBS Press.

Davenport, T.H. (2013) 'Keep up with your quants', Harvard Business Review, 91(7).